

Feminism & Bangladesh: Advanced Quiz

Topic: Feminism & Bangladesh | Difficulty: Hard | Questions: 5 | Model: gemini-2.5-flash

1. Which aspect of the Muslim Family Laws Ordinance (MFLO) of 1961, despite its initial progressive intent, remains a significant point of contention for feminist legal reformers in Bangladesh regarding women's autonomy and equality?

- A. The mandatory registration of marriages.
- B. The requirement for a husband to seek permission for a second marriage.
- C. The lack of explicit codification for women's equal inheritance rights. (correct)**
- D. The provision for 'talaq-e-tafwiz' (delegated divorce).

Explanation: While MFLO introduced progressive elements like marriage registration and restrictions on polygamy, it did not address the fundamental inequality in inheritance laws, which are largely governed by uncodified personal laws that grant women a lesser share than men. This remains a major target for feminist legal reform.

2. The readymade garment (RMG) sector in Bangladesh employs millions of women. From a feminist perspective, which of the following represents the most complex and often overlooked challenge for these workers, beyond basic wage and safety issues?

- A. The prevalence of child labor in ancillary industries.
- B. The lack of access to formal financial credit for entrepreneurial ventures.
- C. The 'double burden' of unpaid care work combined with factory demands. (correct)**
- D. The absence of robust trade union representation.

Explanation: While all options present challenges, the 'double burden' (or 'dual burden') is a core feminist critique. Women garment workers often bear the primary responsibility for household chores and childcare in addition to their demanding factory jobs, leading to severe exhaustion and limited opportunities for rest, skill development, or political participation, a systemic issue often overlooked in conventional labor rights discussions.

3. Begum Rokeya Sakhawat Hossain is a foundational figure in Bengali feminism. Beyond her advocacy for women's education, which of the following lesser-known aspects of her work most directly challenged patriarchal norms regarding women's public mobility and agency?

- A. Her establishment of the Sakhawat Memorial Girls' School.
- B. Her satirical writings critiquing purdah and male dominance. (correct)**
- C. Her advocacy for women's economic independence through vocational training.
- D. Her conceptualization of 'Sultana's Dream' as a utopian feminist vision.

Explanation: While all her contributions were significant, Rokeya's satirical writings, particularly 'Abarodhbasini' (The Secluded Women), directly and humorously exposed the absurdities and injustices of extreme purdah and male-imposed restrictions, thereby challenging the patriarchal norms that limited women's public mobility and agency in a direct and critical manner.

4. In the context of feminist activism in Bangladesh, the rise of religious fundamentalism poses a significant challenge. Which of the following represents the most insidious impact on women's rights, often leading to self-censorship and reduced public participation?

- A. Direct legal challenges to existing secular family laws.
- B. Increased physical violence against women activists.
- C. The propagation of conservative interpretations of religious texts that restrict women's roles. (correct)**
- D. The erosion of state funding for women's empowerment programs.

Explanation: While all options are serious threats, the propagation of conservative religious interpretations is particularly insidious. It works to internalize restrictions, justify them culturally and religiously, and create a social environment where women may self-censor, withdraw from public life, or accept limitations on their rights, even without direct coercion or legal changes.

5. Bangladesh ratified the Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination Against Women (CEDAW) in 1984, but with reservations. Which specific reservation, though modified, continues to be a major point of contention for feminist advocates, hindering full gender equality in personal status laws?

- A. Article 2, concerning the obligation to embody the principle of equality in national constitutions.
- B. Article 13(a), regarding equal rights to family benefits.
- C. Article 16(1)(c), concerning equal rights and responsibilities during marriage and its dissolution. (correct)**
- D. Article 16(1)(f), concerning equal rights and responsibilities regarding guardianship, wardship, trusteeship and adoption of children.

Explanation: Bangladesh initially had reservations on Articles 2, 13(a), 16(1)(c), and 16(1)(f). However, reservations on Articles 2, 13(a), and 16(1)(f) were withdrawn in 2009. The reservation on Article 16(1)(c) was modified but not fully withdrawn, maintaining that it would be applied 'without prejudice to the personal laws of the citizens of Bangladesh.' This clause effectively allows for the continuation of discriminatory practices in personal laws related to marriage and divorce, making it a critical barrier to full gender equality for feminist advocates.

Answer Key

- 1. C** The lack of explicit codification for women's equal inheritance rights.
- 2. C** The 'double burden' of unpaid care work combined with factory demands.
- 3. B** Her satirical writings critiquing purdah and male dominance.
- 4. C** The propagation of conservative interpretations of religious texts that restrict women's roles.
- 5. C** Article 16(1)(c), concerning equal rights and responsibilities during marriage and its dissolution.